

ADVANCING FIRST CLASS PRE-K IN ALABAMA

The Pandemic Test: What Changed for Alabama Pre-K—and What Did Not

Enrollment through the pandemic and against the pre-2020 trajectory, 45 states, 2016–2025

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When the pandemic began, state pre-K enrollment fell across most of the country. In this brief we examine how Alabama fared through that shock, and we report two findings that are both accurate yet point in opposite directions. Measured through the shock itself, Alabama was exceptional, as it was one of just 10 of the 45 operating states whose four-year-old enrollment share *rose* from 2019 to 2021. Measured against its own pre-pandemic trajectory, however, the post-2020 period shows a substantial shortfall: had enrollment continued growing at its 2015–2019 pace, 56.8 percent of four-year-olds would be enrolled today, whereas the actual figure is 40.3 percent, a 16.5-point gap that ranks among the five largest in the country.

Three findings frame the record:

- **Alabama gained ground through the shock.** Enrollment rose from 29 percent in 2019 to 31 percent in 2021 while most states fell (figure 1), a pattern shared by only 10 of 45 states.
- **The growth engine downshifted after 2020.** Alabama had been adding 4.3 percentage points of coverage a year before 2020, and the slower pace since then leaves it 16.5 points below its own extrapolated path (figure 2).

- **Alabama's shortfall is large by national standards.** Of the 45 states, 25 sit below their pre-pandemic trajectory, the median state by 2.4 points, and Alabama's 16.5-point gap is the fifth largest (figure 3).

We treat the trajectory comparison as an extrapolation rather than a causal estimate, because it asks what would have happened had the 2010s pace continued rather than what the pandemic caused, and we return to that distinction throughout.

Two Benchmarks for Pandemic Recovery

How one judges Alabama's recovery depends almost entirely on the benchmark chosen. If the benchmark is 2019, the state recovered long ago and has moved well past that level. If the benchmark is instead the path Alabama was on, namely the sustained expansion that took the state from 6 percent coverage in 2013 to 29 percent in 2019, then recovery has not yet occurred, and the missing growth compounds every year. Both benchmarks are legitimate and simply answer different questions, so we put numbers on each in order that Alabama's expansion debate can choose its benchmark deliberately rather than by default.

This brief is the tenth in the *Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama* series, and it extends the national comparison of brief 4 and the growth history of brief 5 (Lee and Hooper 2026a, 2026b).

BOX 1

Data and Methods

Data. We use the NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbooks, 2016–2025 editions, for the 45 jurisdictions (44 states plus the District of Columbia, called “states” here for brevity) operating a program in both 2019 and 2025; enrollment shares are four-year-olds served by state pre-K.

The trajectory benchmark. For each state we fit a linear trend to its 2015–2019 enrollment shares and extend it to 2025; the “gap” is the actual 2025 share minus that extrapolation. Alabama's fitted trend rises 4.3 points a year. These extrapolations are mechanical, in that they assume the pre-pandemic pace would have continued, and we interpret them accordingly: fast-growing states receive ambitious counterfactuals, and we make no causal claim about what the pandemic did.

Measures. All of our results are descriptive comparisons of reported enrollment shares. The national summary statistics weight states equally.

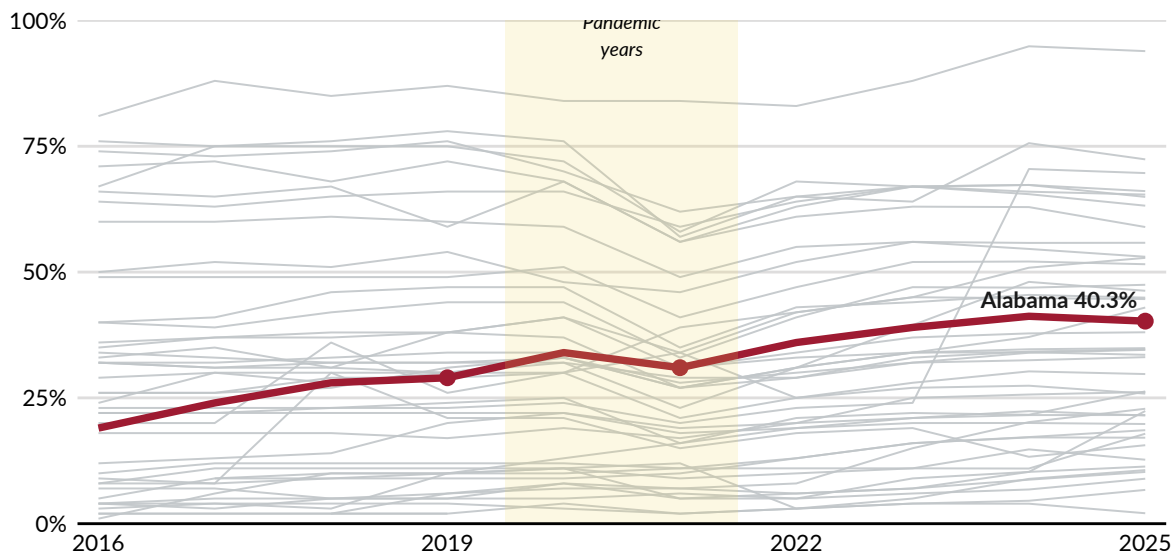
Enrollment through the Pandemic Years

Figure 1 traces every state's enrollment path since 2016, with the pandemic years shaded. Most of the gray lines dip between 2019 and 2021, some of them steeply, whereas Alabama's crimson line leaves the shaded window higher than it entered: we observe coverage edging up from 29 to 31 percent while enrollment fell in classrooms nationwide, making Alabama one of only 10 states to gain ground through the shock.

FIGURE 1

Most States Fell through the Pandemic; Alabama Climbed

Share of four-year-olds enrolled in state pre-K, 45 states, 2016–2025



Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2016–2025 editions.

Notes: The 45 comparison jurisdictions; lines break in years a state did not operate a program (Montana and North Dakota have partial series). The shaded band marks the 2019–2021 pandemic transition. Alabama in crimson.

Program size does not appear to be associated with resilience through the shock, because several large programs contracted sharply, and the episode belongs in the program's record: through the sharpest demand shock early education has faced, Alabama's families continued to enroll and the program continued to seat them.

Enrollment against the Pre-Pandemic Trajectory

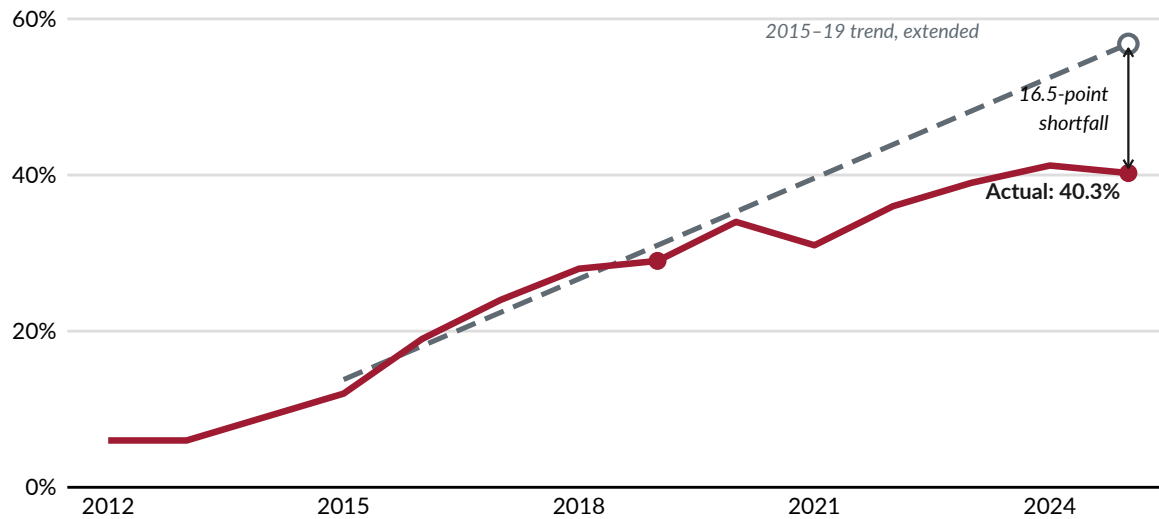
The more demanding benchmark is the one Alabama set for itself. From 2015 to 2019 the state added 4.3 percentage points of coverage a year, the expansion documented in brief 5, and extending that line brings it to 56.8 percent by 2025 (figure 2), against actual 2025 coverage of 40.3 percent. The 16.5-point

difference measures what the post-2020 slowdown has cost relative to the earlier pace, or roughly 9,700 four-year-olds who would be enrolled today had the 2010s trajectory held.¹

FIGURE 2

Actual Enrollment versus the Pre-Pandemic Path

Alabama's share of four-year-olds enrolled, actual and 2015–19 trend extended, 2012–2025



Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2012–2025 editions.

Notes: The dashed line extends a linear fit to 2015–2019 shares (+4.3 points per year). The extrapolation assumes the pre-pandemic pace would have continued; it is a benchmark, not a causal estimate.

An extrapolation this ambitious deserves a caveat, because no growth curve rises indefinitely and a 4.3-point annual pace would likely have saturated at some point. Yet the recent record does not support treating the slowdown as inevitable maturation: the state added 17 points of coverage in the four years *before* the pandemic (2015–2019) and about 9 in the four years since (2021–2025), and the waitlists documented in brief 9 suggest that demand remains unmet.

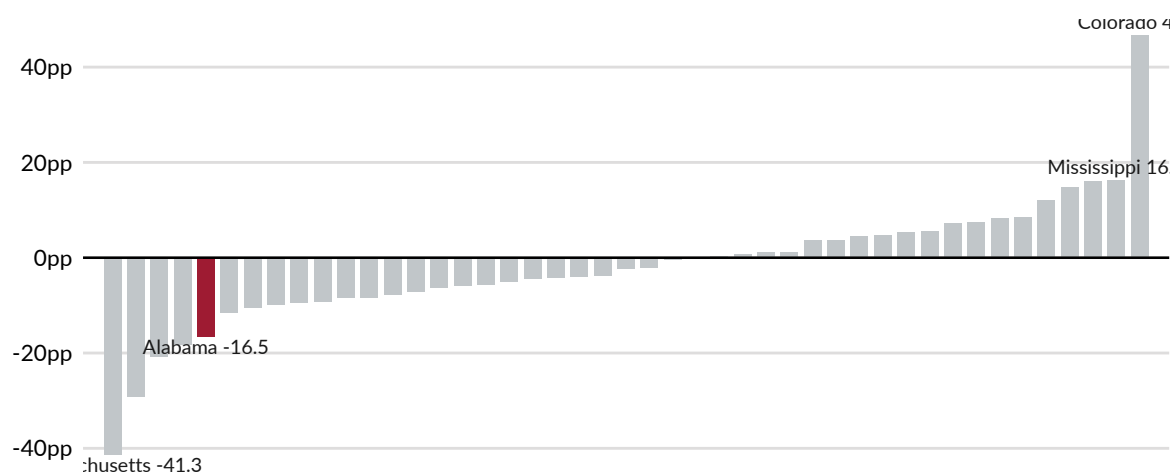
Trajectory Gaps across the 45 States

Although the trajectory test is not uniquely harsh on Alabama, the state fares worse than most (figure 3). Of the 45 states, 25 sit below their pre-pandemic path and 20 at or above it, and the median state falls 2.4 points short. Alabama's 16.5-point gap is the fifth largest, in the company of Massachusetts—41.3 points short of an admittedly steep path—and Vermont; at the other end, Colorado's universal-pre-K launch put it 46.7 points *above* its old trend.

FIGURE 3

Alabama's Shortfall Is the Fifth Largest of 45 States

2025 enrollment share minus the state's extended 2015–19 trend, in percentage points



Source: Authors' analysis of NIEER *State of Preschool* yearbook data, 2015–2025 editions.

Notes: Positive values sit above the state's extrapolated pre-pandemic path. Gaps reflect both pandemic effects and each state's subsequent policy choices; states with steep pre-2020 growth receive ambitious benchmarks.

The cross-state ranking partly reflects how the benchmark is built. A steeper pre-2020 trend produces a more ambitious extrapolation and therefore a larger measured shortfall, so the states farthest below trend are, by construction, disproportionately those that had been growing fastest. Read with that in mind, the ranking says less about which states the shock hit hardest than about which had set themselves the fastest pace beforehand. What it does show is that some states resumed that pace and others did not: Colorado, New Mexico, and Mississippi are among those that did, and their recovery looks like deliberate post-2020 policy rather than automatic rebound.

Discussion

The two benchmarks we report describe different aspects of the same record, and the most useful thing a reader can do with them is to say which one is in use. “Recovered and growing,” measured against 2019, and “16.5 points behind,” measured against the pre-pandemic trajectory, are both accurate statements about Alabama. Budget requests, agency reporting, and advocacy may each reach for the frame that suits them, and our contribution here is to place both frames on the table with their numbers attached.

The cross-state evidence also suggests that re-acceleration is a choice other states have made rather than a process that occurs on its own, since resumed expansion is associated with deliberate post-2020 policy rather than with the passage of time. Alabama's own 2015–2019 pace of 4.3 points a year was

itself sustained policy, and the scenario arithmetic of brief 9, which puts the requirement at about 291 classrooms to reach 50 percent, describes what resuming deliberate growth would likely take.

Although the resilience finding is easy to overstate, it is worth keeping in the record. Emerging from the shock with rising enrollment was rare, as only 10 states did so, and it may reflect a degree of family trust in the program that might be difficult to rebuild if it were lost. It is a reasonable opening to the growth case, provided that the trajectory number is reported alongside it.

Limitations

These analyses have several limitations. The trajectory is an extrapolation that assumes the 2015–2019 pace would have continued, when real growth would likely have slowed as coverage rose, so the 16.5-point figure benchmarks the slowdown rather than measuring lost demand. We also offer no causal decomposition, because the gap mixes pandemic disruption, appropriations choices, population change, and saturation dynamics, and these data cannot separate them. Cross-state comparability is loose as well, since states differ in program definitions and reporting and our equal-weighted summaries treat Wyoming and Texas alike. Finally, enrollment is not access: a rising share indicates that seats were filled, not that every family who wanted one found one, and brief 9 documents the waitlists behind the shares.

Despite these limitations, the pandemic record read whole returns a split assessment, in that Alabama protected its program through the shock better than most other states and has since lost momentum along with most of them. Which of those two facts governs the next five years is a policy choice rather than a question these data can settle.

Notes

- ¹ 16.5 percent of the 59,016 four-year-olds in the 2024–25 planning estimates is about 9,700 children. That count applies a NIEER-based share to the state administrative denominator; NIEER's own population base would put the figure near 9,900. Either way it is an extrapolation, not a measured shortfall in demand.

References

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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

The Advancing First Class Pre-K in Alabama project examines First Class Pre-K funding, implementation, access, and comparisons with other state pre-K programs. Its goal is to offer recommendations for expanding First Class Pre-K while maintaining high levels of quality.

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